

1. What is the topic you would like to research?

I would love to research more on digital compression from AI and the hidden algorithms used in them, and what happens to data that is lost or altered through these conversion processes

2. Why are you interested in this topic?

Especially in the digital age, where sharing files, information or even just text, there are hundreds of algorithms that are used to optimize data online. JPG compression, ZIP files, uploading an image on Instagram. Every time, however, the data over time slowly shifts and changes, losing parts of what makes it the “original data”. Especially with AI-generated content, services like “summarizers” or “upscaling” can obscure data in content online.

3. Why is it a worthwhile topic to explore?

Everything we consume is data. The movies we watch, the posts we like, the content we read. By not understanding the process of conversion that happens online, we are putting users online in a state of simulacra, without understanding why the content we enjoy can change.

4. How can design contribute to this topic area?

Design can bring information or metaphors to compression to light. Image compression can be very abstract and hard for people to understand or care about. My hope for this thesis is not only to visualize the effects of compression in a digestible format, but to challenge the simple process of interacting with content online.

5. Think about these elements of the topic:

a. Who is involved? Is there a specific population?

Users on the web who want convenient ways to interact with content online, but don't know the ramifications of these convenient ways of posting or “summarizing” content. AI dependent power users especially, when relating to users who use AI to alter data, as the processes appear neutral, but hide biases in their algorithm.

b. What are the issues/problems at hand?

These algorithms are a hidden process and are hard to see or explain. For example, when you upload a photo to your instagram, instagram places their own compression algorithms on your photo to make it lighter on their database. How can I make someone care about data compression, and show the process between uploading to online

c. Is there a location/context you want to focus on?

While not fully defined, I would like to see how professional services interact with “compression” in content, whether it be using AI to summarize or edit, or using programs to upscale or generate on top of an image. It would be relevant to see why users

compress data, and the thought process behind these process, looking at the benefits of these algorithms.